

*Oreamnos americanus*

## Mountain goat



**Location** W. Canada, N. and W. USA

**Length** 4½–5¼ ft (1.4–1.8 m)

**Tail** 4–8 in (10–20 cm)

**Weight** 130–250 lb (60–115 kg)

**Social unit** Variable

**Status** Least concern



This woolly haired goat survives among ice, snow, rocks, and glaciers. Its large, sharp hooves have hard rims and soft inner pads, to grip slippery surfaces, and its long, yellow-white outer coat and thick, dense underfur conserve body heat. The sharp, back-curved horns are up to 11¼ in (30 cm) long and are slightly thicker in males, which may be 30 percent larger than females. These goats feed on grass, moss, lichens, and twigs. It forms single-sex groups, except in the mating season.

*Rupicapra rupicapra*

## Alpine chamois



**Location** S. Europe, W. Asia

**Length** 3¾–4¼ ft (1.1–1.3 m)

**Tail** 3–4 in (8–10 cm)

**Weight** 55–130 lb (25–60 kg)

**Social unit** Individual/Group

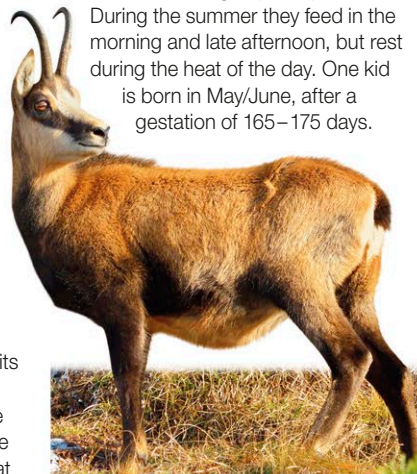
**Status** Least concern



The Alpine chamois is an agile climber, able to leap 6½ ft (2 m) high, spring 20 ft (6 m) along, and run at 31 mph (50 kph)—its flexible hoof pads giving sure grip on uneven, slippery terrain. Both sexes have slender, black, close-set horns, which are up to 11 in (28 cm) long, and curve back at

the tips. It feeds on herbs and flowers in alpine pastures during summer, and moves lower in winter for mosses, lichens, and shoots, as groups disperse.

During the summer they feed in the morning and late afternoon, but rest during the heat of the day. One kid is born in May/June, after a gestation of 165–175 days.

*Capra ibex*

## Alpine ibex



**Location** S. Europe

**Length** 1¾–4¼ ft (0.5–1.3 m)

**Tail** 6–11¼ in (15–29 cm)

**Weight** 88–265 lb (40–120 kg)

**Social unit** Individual/Group

**Status** Least concern



The Alpine ibex dwells at or above the tree line, up to 15,780 ft (4,810 m). The female has a tan coat in summer and the male a rich brown one with yellow-white patches on the back and rump. Both sexes grow a thicker winter coat of more variable color. In spring, they migrate up to alpine pasture, descending in fall to browse buds and shoots. Females and young form stable groups of 10–20; males form single-sex herds.

## CLASH OF HORNS



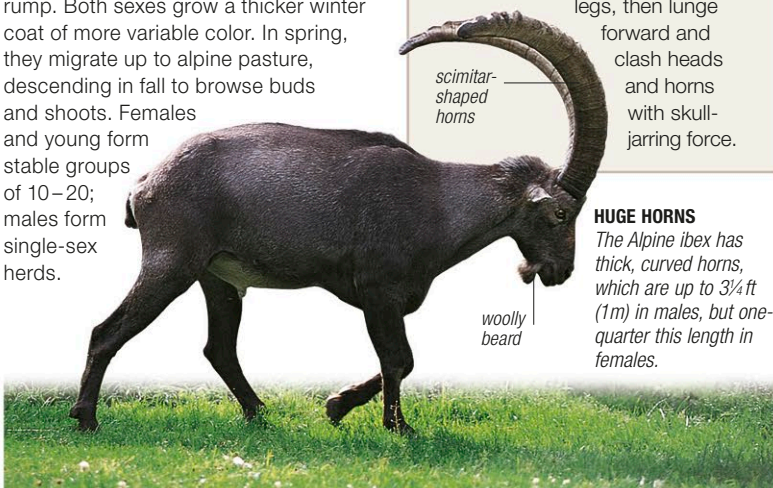
Like many wild (and domestic) goats, male Alpine ibex compete for herd dominance and females by postures, head tosses, and fights. Opponents rear up on their back legs, then lunge forward and clash heads and horns with skull-jarring force.

scimitar-shaped horns

## HUGE HORNS

The Alpine ibex has thick, curved horns, which are up to 3¼ ft (1 m) in males, but one-quarter this length in females.

woolly beard

*Hemitragus jemlahicus*

## Himalayan tahr



**Location** S. Asia

**Length** 3–5½ ft (0.9–1.7 m)

**Tail** 3½–4¼ in (9–12 cm)

**Weight** 120–270 lb (55–124 kg)

**Social unit** Group

**Status** Near threatened



The sure-footed Himalayan tahr has a shaggy, conspicuous mane on its neck and shoulders, extending to its knees; its face and head fur are contrastingly short. The horns, flattened from side to side, reach up to 11¼ in (30 cm) long in males—twice as long as in females. Like many mountain mammals, the Himalayan tahr migrates high into the mountains in

spring, to browse and graze in mixed forests at altitudes of 16,500 ft (5,000 m). It returns to temperate forests as low as 8,250 ft (2,500 m) in fall, when herds of

2–23 females are joined by rutting males, who lock horns and try to topple each other off balance. Young are born the following May or June.



reddish brown coat

very short tail

*Ovibos moschatus*

## Muskox



**Location** N. North America, Greenland

**Length** 6¼–7½ ft (1.9–2.3 m)

**Tail** 3½–4 in (9–10 cm)

**Weight** 440–900 lb (200–410 kg)

**Social unit** Group

**Status** Least concern



The muskox is named after the strong odor of rutting males, who charge and ram each other for females. Both sexes have broad horns, which nearly

meet at a central boss, curving down and then up at the tips. The body is massive; the neck, legs, and tail are short. In summer, the muskox grazes valley sedges and grasses. In winter, it browses on higher ground, where wind keeps the ground clear of snow. Almost exterminated by humans, the muskox has recovered through wildlife management and reintroductions.

## DOUBLE COAT

The muskox's outer coat of dark brown guard hairs reaches almost to the ground, to shed rain and snow effectively. The undercoat of fine, soft, pale brown hair provides excellent insulation.



shoulder hump

paler midback

pale legs

## DEFENSIVE CIRCLE

When threatened—for example, from wolves or a polar bear—adult male and female muskoxen gather in a circle, facing outward. The vulnerable youngsters are protected in the middle. Larger herd members may break from the circle to charge or otherwise intimidate the enemy.

